

The CPA Firm Offshore Readiness Checklist

A practical, partner-level guide for US CPA firm owners considering offshore tax, accounting and advisory support — covering readiness, ideal tasks, security, workflow and how to evaluate the right partner.

What you'll get from this guide

- A clear yes / no on whether your firm is ready for offshore right now
- The 12 tasks most CPA firms safely outsource first
- A security & confidentiality checklist your IT lead will approve
- A workflow preparation checklist to avoid season-one chaos
- A busy season planning guide built around offshore capacity
- A vendor scoring rubric for evaluating offshore partners

01 · Readiness

Is your firm ready for offshore support?

Score each statement Yes / No. Six or more 'Yes' answers means you're ready.

- We can describe at least one repeatable task we wish we didn't do.
- We have a defined review checklist (even if informal).
- We use one of CCH Axcess, UltraTax, ProConnect or Drake.
- We have a secure document portal (or are willing to adopt one).
- We can dedicate 1 partner / manager as a point of contact.
- We are open to a small pilot before scaling.
- Our team uses a defined client folder structure.
- We have prior-year workpapers accessible for context.

02 · Tasks Ideal for Outsourcing

Start with these.

- Form 1040 preparation (individual returns, including Sch C, E, K-1 reconciliations)
- Form 1065 partnership preparation and K-1 generation
- Form 1120 / 1120-S corporate preparation
- Form 990 non-profit preparation
- First-level review on staff-prepared returns
- Quarterly tax projections and safe-harbor estimates
- Bookkeeping and monthly reconciliations in QuickBooks
- Tax notice triage and response drafting
- Engagement-letter and organizer preparation
- Workpaper standardization and tickmarking
- Amended return preparation
- Off-season cleanup and bookkeeping catch-up

03 · Security & Confidentiality

Security & confidentiality checklist.

- Signed NDA before any client data is shared
- All work performed inside firm-approved environments (no local downloads)
- MFA on every system: email, software, document portal
- Encrypted document portal (SmartVault, ShareFile, Suralink, etc.)
- Background checks / ID verification on offshore staff
- Workstation policy — no removable media, locked screen on idle
- Audit trail on document access and tax software usage
- Annual security review meeting between firm and partner

04 · Workflow Preparation

Set yourself up to win in season one.

- Standardize your client folder structure and document naming
- Document your firm's review checklist — even one page is enough
- Define what 'review-ready' means at your firm (workpaper standards, tickmarks)
- Assign a single point of contact at the firm (not 4 people in parallel)
- Agree turnaround SLAs in writing (e.g., 5 business days for 1040)
- Use a shared status tracker — TaxDome, Karbon, Liscio, or a simple sheet
- Schedule a 15-minute weekly status call during busy season
- Plan capacity for surge weeks (last 2 weeks of March, first 2 of April)

05 · Busy Season Planning

A repeatable busy season plan.

- November: confirm offshore capacity and lock SLAs for the coming season
- December: dry-run the document handoff for 5 sample clients
- January: ramp begins; first 25 returns prepared and reviewed end-to-end
- February: hit weekly throughput targets; weekly status call live
- March: peak weeks — surge capacity activated; daily standups if needed
- April: extensions filed, post-season retro within 10 days of 4/15
- Off-season: amended returns, notices, planning work, training updates

06 · Evaluating an Offshore Partner

Scoring rubric — score each 1–5.

- Direct access to the actual preparer (not just an account manager)
- Hands-on experience with your tax software
- Form coverage: 1040, 1065, 1120, 1120-S, 990
- Documented quality control and review approach
- Tax planning capability beyond compliance
- Time-zone overlap with US working hours
- Pilot / small-scale engagement available
- Clear security posture and NDA process
- References or anonymized case studies available
- Communication discipline (response SLAs, weekly status)

A score of 40+ out of 50 typically indicates a strong partner.

Next step

Take the Free CPA Capacity Audit at rahultaxadvisory.com/audit — a 15-minute assessment that maps your firm's specific bottlenecks to an offshore support model.

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